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Bob Havens

Bob Havens was born in Quincy, Illinois on May 3, 1930. He showed an early aptitude for music, studying the violin and piano and eventually excelling on the trombone. He cites his visit to New Orleans in 1956 as an important career move, one which led to a four year stint with trumpeter Al Hirt. Bob has had important roles with two American institutions, Lawrence Welk and Disneyland. He spent 22 years with the Welk Orchestra and was often the featured trombonist on the TV show. He also found time to perform traditional jazz with Sharkey Bonono and Armand Hug. Bob currently performs with the Lawrence Welk production in Branford, Missouri and is a familiar guest at jazz parties around the country.

Bob was interviewed at the Allegheny Jazz Party in Chautauqua, New York on September 12, 1997 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today in Chautauqua, New York for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and my guest today is Bob Havens, trombonist. Welcome.

BH: Well, it's a pleasure to be here, Monk.

MR: Is it a bit of a challenge to fit this in during this weekend? They have you working pretty hard.

BH: Yes, they have us going a number of times each day, and so I have — well I haven't counted up the sets but I think it's like nine or ten sets over a period of about three days.

MR: Somehow jazz at nine AM doesn't seem quite right.

BH: I've always felt that way. I have never liked to play early in the day. My mind just doesn't get going at full momentum that early.

MR: You were born in Illinois.

BH: That's right. I was born in Quincy, Illinois.

MR: Can you recall, as a child, what the first kinds of music that made an impression on you were?

BH: Well when I was quite young, well I would go back probably to my grade school years, the first thing I remember musically is my mother used to work at a music store and she sold sheet music and records. And during that time she brought home a lot of samples, like old recordings — these would date back into the twenties. And that's the first thing I remember is having this wind-up victrola in the home. It was considered a console model, where you put the record on the top and the sound came out the bottom through an inside horn. So we always had these records in our attic area. And I would go up to the attic and bring down a stack of records and I would just put them on one by one. And I would say mostly it was recordings of large orchestras, such as Paul Whiteman and the Benson Orchestra of Chicago. I'm just naming names that come to me, it probably doesn't mean

anything to anybody nowadays, and Charlie Straight was another orchestra that I listened to. And I became acquainted with the dance orchestras of the time by just playing these records. And of course at that time I wasn't particularly — my mind wasn't directed toward jazz at any particular amount at that time, and I was just becoming acquainted with music. I did it by records. But another fortunate thing was that my mother and father were both musical. And we had a family ritual, after an evening meal we would gather around the family piano and my mother played the piano, and she would get a big stack of music and just start pulling out things and playing and I would listen and sort of sing along at that time, until I reached the age of about six or seven years old. And they decided maybe I ought to learn an instrument. By that time they'd observed that I was a lot interested in music, because I would do this on my own.

MR: Let me ask you something about — you used the term "family piano," in that the way families entertained themselves back then were obviously different than now.

BH: Yes.

MR: And was the piano a thing of luxury?

BH: Well in those days we didn't have television at all so we had to think of other things to entertain ourselves in the evening hours. And of course also the real popular thing was the radio. But we spent probably as much time or maybe more time, just with the music that we got out of the piano, and in later years I took up the violin when I was about six or seven years old. So I would do my thing on the violin. I got to where I could read the sheet music and I'd do that. My father played the bass fiddle and also the cello. So we'd just go through the stack of music quite often in the evenings. And that's really where I learned a lot of music, by memory. Because we did this so often that it just sort of stuck with me.

MR: Well that's a great place to learn it. And hearing the other instruments with you, too, is valuable.

BH: Yes. That's true, yeah.

MR: Was there a point where you decided, in your teens perhaps, that you were going to be a musician?

BH: Not professionally. I really hadn't made up my mind that that was the particular direction I was going to go in after my schooling. But I definitely was quite interested. Well I was probably about eight years old when I was — well two doors down the street from where I lived was a trombone player. And he played in the old days in vaudeville theatres. He used to play for the vaudeville acts in the little pit orchestra. So well I'd already started on the violin. So my mother and father were acquainted with Mr. Paul Morrison. He was the instructor at the local Quincy High School. And he said to my mother and father, you know, "It's nice that Bob is playing the violin, but why don't we see if we can get him a

brass instrument also. Maybe we could work him in to the marching band when he gets older." So they took me down to the music store and at that point I didn't know what instrument I might want to play. So they had all these instruments on the wall, just sort of hanging there, and they said, "Look up there and pick out an instrument that you think you might like to learn." And I didn't know really one from another basically, so I just happened to point to the trombone. Well it was fortunate that just very close to where we lived was a trombone player, Mr. Mayhall. So they had a convenient instructor there. So Mr. Mayhall started giving me lessons. I was about eight years old. And I guess I was somewhat a slow learner at that time, about certain things. Maybe not about the music, but my teacher said, "You know I think you're going to learn to play the horn before you learn how to put it in the case." Because I never could remember how to get it in the case.

MR: No kidding. How to take it apart?

BH: How to take it apart and get it the right side up.

MR: You're lucky you didn't play the bassoon or something like that, you never would have got it in.

BH: But I took formal lessons maybe three or four years on the trombone. And also I might add that I also started on piano, because we had a piano at home. And my mother knew another piano player that was a good teacher. So she started me out on the piano and the trombone, practically at the same time. And so I just started showing various talents in different directions you know, and also I ended up taking tap dance lessons.

MR: No kidding.

BH: And at one time I was taking violin lessons, trombone lessons, tap dance lessons, and some voice lessons. So I was getting a little bit of everything.

MR: Would you like to show us a little of your tap dance routine?

BH: I don't think so. I think I know maybe two steps and that's about all I can remember.

MR: Well you were, let's see, in the late 30s then and early 40s, you were a young boy, were you aware of the Swing era that was becoming —

BH: I really wasn't aware that it was a particularly new thing, the Swing Era. All I knew is what I heard on the records. I didn't know what came before it, years before — I just started tuning my ear into what was happening in those days. And fortunately I did grow up in what we now consider the big band era in popular music. And I listened to many, many records, besides the real old stuff back in the '20s, of Paul Whiteman, I listened to Benny Goodman and of course in the '40s the Glenn Miller Band was popular, and all of the old big bands that became a popular item, I listened to on records. And I had quite a large record collection after nine or ten years of collecting my own things, after my mother and father already got started on it years ago. So I grew to like the popular music and I also, I really got tuned in to a lot of variety of music by recordings. And I took an

interest in the classical music. The only part of music I never really got interested in was the Opera singing. I never, well to this day I really don't enjoy it to listen to it. But I do like the music that goes along with it see, and the orchestra I'm quite interested in. But I have an interest in the classics as well as the jazz that I picked up along the way. And I think I probably had a natural tendency to tune in on the jazz aspect of the music. I became interested in what the individuals were doing on these recording, like the trumpet or the trombone. And of course I heard a lot of Tommy Dorsey's recordings but of course Tommy was not considered a jazz player. But my trombone teacher really kind of pushed that style a lot and wanted me to listen to a lot of Dorsey records. But I don't know, it was pretty, but I just didn't quite — it didn't really catch my ear that much.

MR: He had great breath control.

BH: Very good breath control. And his tone quality was superb. And it showed, all of this, on his recordings. Well I would say when I was ten or eleven years old I'd been playing a couple of years on the trombone and I picked things up very quickly as far as jazz is concerned. I was really having a lot of fun learning that kind of music. And even by the time I was ten or eleven years old, I was playing in my father's orchestra. He had a little orchestra and I would play in this little five or six piece band for different things around Quincy. So I got an early start. And I can recall many days in my schooling days, in grade school, I would go in to school and I would fall asleep in class because the night before I had been playing a dance somewhere.

MR: You say, "Teacher, I had a gig, what can I do?" Did your father pay you?

BH: No I don't think he really did. But it wasn't very long after that, I was about twelve years old and I — well the word kind of got around that I was I guess an up-and-coming player in town. So I auditioned with another piano player in town who had an orchestra and he came to my house and I played a few tunes with him and he hired me to play in his orchestra. As a matter of fact you have his first name also, Monk.

MR: No kidding.

BH: Monk Huffman in Quincy, was a piano player. So I started playing with his orchestra. Then another band kind of got the word and well I also started playing with a group called the Red Ramblers Orchestra. And we had a violin and guitar and drums, and bass and piano. I think that was it.

MR: So this music that you were playing at this time, was it somewhat improvised?

BH: Well improvisation was something that came to me easy. I didn't ever really have to practice on that. It just was a natural thing that came to me. And I feel really fortunate that I grew to like jazz music and I fortunately have no problem in learning it, you know, picking it up. I can hear something and I can play it on my horn right away. Just anything that I can hear I can play it on the horn. And of course you sort of automatically create a

situation in your mind where you usually hear things that you know you can play on the horn.

MR: If you can't play it you can't hear it.

BH: You usually automatically kind of keep within your boundaries on the things that you sort of cook up in your mind.

MR: How did World War II affect your community, your family, or just your daily life?

BH: Well of course I was in school and my father did not have much formal schooling, I think he had to quit when he was about eight years old and go to work. He came from a community in Indiana, Kokomo, and he had to go to work in the foundry there. And then he sort of migrated from Indiana to Illinois, after a divorce in his family, then he moved on and he and my mother I think were married about 1921. And I didn't come along until 1930. So my father, due to his lack of education, he was kind of like a custodian in a school. And we were not considered much more than somewhere in between a poor and medium income family. And so I didn't have the real finer things of life. But I did have my records and my sheet music and as far as I was concerned I had everything I wanted. But I did grow up in the war years there. And as a matter of fact I became involved in a lot of community music activities at that age. And I played, entertained the servicemen in World War II. We had — in those days we had minstrel shows you know. And I think it's sort of outlawed these days, we don't do that anymore. But I was involved in some local minstrel shows and we traveled around to various Army camps and put on shows for them. And I played in the pit orchestra along with my father and he also was a very strong bass singer, besides playing the bass fiddle.

MR: Were these minstrel shows, when you did it for the servicemen, were the audiences segregated so that you were playing just for the white soldiers?

BH: Yes. That's the way I remember it. Well I don't remember what happened in the Army camps. But when we played locally in Quincy it was a segregated audience at that time. I wasn't aware of any segregation at that time. It just didn't register with me that that's what was going on you know. But it was fun. I enjoyed playing the shows. We had the "end men" in blackface. My father was a member of the chorus I guess you'd call it. And he would have a bass solo and sang a number in the program. But I played in the pit orchestra. But that was one activity that I had during the war years. Then I was a member of the drum and bugle corps. I started out in that when I was twelve years old and I played the baritone bugle. And that was a lot of fun. And we were sponsored by the American Legion Club in Quincy and we entered contests, the corps contests in the State of Illinois, and that continued from when I was about twelve years old through about age eighteen I guess, all the way through my high school days. I got real good formal training, especially in the high school days. I had a really good band instructor, Mr. Paul

Morrison, and I was exposed through his tutoring also to composition. After school he would gather us together, a few of the most promising students in music and conduct a harmony class. So he would teach us how to write music, of course teaching the chords and everything that you would eventually need to know to like compose a march — and that was our first project, was to write a march that you would play in the band, the concert band. So after some of his training, I started writing some pieces. And I wrote two band marches and I found out not too long ago that those two band marches are still in the library—

MR: At your high school?

BH: At my high school, yeah.

MR: That's neat.

BH: And as a matter of fact I think it was about twenty years ago, they invited me back to conduct one of the numbers, just a guest conductor. And they chose one of my compositions. And I wrote the first one when I was sixteen years old, and the second one a year later. And I had started to write an overture by the time that I was ready to be graduated from school. I never quite finished that one.

MR: The Unfinished Opus.

BH: Well Schubert has his Unfinished Symphony. I have my Unfinished Overture.

MR: Let me skip up to when you made the move to New Orleans and what happened in that period in your life?

BH: Okay. Well I'll just briefly say that trombone became my favorite instrument. I played the violin all the way through high school and even a little with the local symphony afterwards. But trombone became my favorite and I eventually dropped the violin all together. And my father brought home a record from his place where he worked, and it was a Red Nichols and the Five Pennies recording. And on that record was Jack Teagarden. That was my first introduction to the sound of Jack Teagarden. And this was about 1947 I guess. Well I fell in love with his style right away. Now from the years where I got out of high school and I went in the Army and spent a couple of years in the Army, and during the period when I was about 18 years old until about 25, I was kind of mentally going back and forth between what was considered bebop music and Dixieland music and swing music — sort of three different styles there. So at that point I really didn't know exactly what I wanted to play, and I didn't even know if I was going to be a professional musician or not. As a matter of fact I learned another trade, through the suggestion of my father. He said, "Music is great, but you ought to learn something else in case the music goes sour." So I learned to be a radio and television repairman. I went to school in Chicago. But then I worked for Motorola and I played music at night in Quincy. Well then I went in the Army in 1952, and spent 18 months in the National

Guard from Illinois, and I was in the Division band, the marching band. Then when I got out of the Army I went to work as a radio repairman in a local shop and playing music at night. Finally in 1955 I got a phone call and it was a man by the name of John Strophe. Ten years before this John and I were students in a music camp, Interlochen Music Camp in Michigan. Well we never corresponded after that. And here ten years had elapsed and he was playing with the Ralph Flanagan Orchestra, traveling through Quincy doing a concert. And he called me and he said, "I remembered that this was your home town." And so he picked me out of the phone book and called me and said, "I'd love to see you again, come down and listen to our concert." And they were putting on a concert at the local high school where I had played many times. So I went down and found out that they were looking for an extra trombone man in the band. Of course he had already said, "Why don't you bring your horn" not knowing what he had in mind. Well music was always a great interest at that point and so Mr. Flanagan asked me if I would play a few songs for him, that I'd been recommended by John Strophe. So I played a few tunes with the piano and he liked my playing so much he said, "Would you join my band?" And it took me just a few seconds to decide. I thought well I really would rather play music. So I left Quincy in '55 and joined Ralph Flanagan in Texas in November, and that was the beginning of my professional career. It was a big band, it was a popular band in the early 50s. And I played with him and the first stop after about a month was in New Orleans, after touring Texas. We played an engagement at the Roosevelt Hotel in New Orleans and at that point I had already realized that Dixieland was my favorite kind of jazz music. And it's what I felt like I did the best at. So I could hardly wait to get through work at the hotel and go on Bourbon Street, and I brought my horn with me and I listened to as many bands as I could in the course of a few evenings. And they asked me to sit in and play. I got acquainted with George Gerard and his band he called the New Orleans Five. I sat in with the band and after I finished playing he offered me a job. And it was my second night in New Orleans.

MR: This is too easy.

BH: Yeah. Here I've only been with Flanagan one month and now I'm on Bourbon Street and I get another offer, and it took me about ten seconds to decide I'd rather play Dixieland than the big band. I finished the tour with Flanagan and four months later I came back to New Orleans and played with George's band. And I was in New Orleans for five years. And I played with George and after a year or two I switched over to Al Hirt's jazz band. And Al had started a band. Of course you know in later years he became a big name in the music business. But he and Pete Fountain and I were the original members of the front line of this band in 1957. As you know, Pete Fountain has his own band in New Orleans and is doing very well, and Al is still playing in Bourbon Street and has done

awfully well in his career, and so I got my start in New Orleans. I call it my apprenticeship in jazz.

MR: The music that you were playing then, do you think it was similar or has it changed from King Oliver's and Louis Armstrong's, early on in jazz.

BH: Well I think Dixieland primarily is still the same type of music that it was. It was considered the first type of jazz music. Well first at the turn of the century was I guess what you'd call ragtime music, which was mostly played on the piano. Then the Dixieland bands started out with the Original Dixieland band out of New Orleans, and basically it was played then just about the same as it is now. But there is some influence between other styles of music that have sort of gotten into the simple Dixieland style. Modern jazz sort of came along — well first we had Dixieland, like World War I and on the way through, and then in the first part of the thirties, I guess the Swing era started to come through with the Benny Goodman and the big bands. And the Dixieland influence I think has always been there no matter what style it is. There's that simple influence that most musicians tend to learn before they go into anything else.

MR: This particular festival is not oriented toward Dixieland too much.

BH: No.

MR: Do you make the other ones that are?

BH: Yes. Well I don't know. The biggest — well the festival that is considered the largest in the country is considered a Dixieland festival and that's the one in Sacramento. And I was there when it started out, in 1974 I think. It was directed towards the Dixieland style groups, small groups. And I think it has grown into the largest festival in existence of that style. And it still is presented in such a way that the trumpet generally carries the simple lead and the trombone generally plays bass notes or a little more ambitious than the bass, which is the job of the trombone player in a Dixieland band. And the clarinet plays the obbligato above the melody, and that's pretty much the way they still play it. It's a simple type of music.

MR: Right. Most of those bands use tubas instead of bass players?

BH: Yeah. It started out, well back in the twenties I guess, the string bass just never quite carried very well on recordings, the old primitive, acoustical recordings. The string bass didn't carry so the tuba seemed to have a little more power on recordings and so they used that. But in later years I think the string bass became just about as popular as the tuba with the small band. And I personally prefer a string bass in my band when I have one. I like the string bass and the piano. But there are other groups that — some would consider purists. The purists go back to the days when they used mostly banjos and tubas. That seems to be two instruments that go together. Now it was never one of my favorite combinations. So I lean towards the other direction.

MR: Okay. Well tell me about Lawrence Welk.

BH: Lawrence Welk, okay. Well I got started, I went and played in a Dixieland band and in Al Hirt's band, and of course Mr. Welk got his start back in the thirties and worked his way up as a big orchestra leader, and he developed a style known as the "champagne style" which is kind of a bubbly sound, like Shep Fields. They were both going in the same direction. Well Mr. Welk came through town and stopped in at this Dance Pier 600 where I was working with Al Hirt, and he listened to the band all evening. And he liked the way I played the trombone very much. And well first Pete Fountain was asked by Mr. Welk to join his band. This was 1958. Well Pete left our group and joined Welk. And two years later Pete came back and started his own band. Well now Mr. Welk, having heard me play before and heard me again, he decided well he'd like to have me play in his orchestra too. So I decided to go with his orchestra in 1960.

MR: Excuse me, was this pre-TV? Was he traveling the country like other bands?

BH: Lawrence was known as a territory band. There were hundreds of territory type bands that just played engagements in hotels and just like a circuit, like all the bands were doing. Lawrence started out in the midwest, from the Dakotas. And in 1948 he migrated with his band to the west coast. And he began playing at the Aragon Ballroom in Santa Monica. Well through good management he landed a job with his orchestra on a local television, in 1954 I think it was. In '55 the Chrysler Company, the Dodge people, picked him as a replacement for "The Jackie Gleason Show" on television. So after years of local television, he worked his way to a national show. Well from that point on his popularity just grew by leaps and bounds. And he found himself able to sort of look around and get the cream of the crop through all existing musicians. So he'd heard me play. See I had a specialty that I started doing with Al Hirt, and that was somebody asked me to play a solo on "Tiger Rag." Well it was a real fast number and somebody came in and said, "Well you know there's a trombone player down the street that plays Tiger Rag, can you do that?" This was just a customer. And I said, "Well I don't do that as a solo but I could try." And I didn't know what the other fellow did, I just — well he must be doing something special. So I just started acting like a clown. You know I'd play and I would lay on the floor, and move the slide with my foot and kind of like a circus act. And this fellow just went crazy over what I did, along with the rest of the audience. And I thought well that's the end of that, I won't have to do that anymore, hopefully. The next night a bunch of people came in and says, "We saw you do this thing where you lay on the floor," and you know this became a nightly routine and I had to keep doing it and keep doing it, and it has become a trademark with me ever since. And this is what caught Mr. Welk's eye. He saw me do that one night and he said, "Anybody that can do that," (playing the trombone laying on his back and moving the slide with his foot) "anybody

that can do that should be on my show." So that was really singularly responsible for getting me the job, just that one song.

MR: I'll be darned.

BH: But of course he did like my playing other than that. But that started my career with the champagne music. And it lasted twenty-two years.

MR: Twenty-two years.

BH: And I thought I might last about six months, being a jazz player. But I did find out that Mr. Welk loved jazz music and he had said to me before that he sometimes wished that he had started a jazz band because he liked it so well.

MR: Well it's curious because last week, I was just reading about you and I turned on the television and I'll be darned if there wasn't a Lawrence Welk special on, it was hosted by — I can't remember her name, the blonde woman who played the kind of rag-timey piano?

BH: Joanne Castle.

MR: Yeah. So she was hosting the show and they were doing this show, little spots. And they featured you on a thing, you came out front.

BH: I had just started playing in Branson, Missouri this last April — Lawrence Welk's son, Larry Junior, four years ago built a theatre in Branson, and now there's a Lawrence Welk Theatre, and he asked me to come in and do a season with the band. So I've been there since April and I'll be there through December of this year.

MR: Well you were doing — I can't remember the name of the tune — but at the end of it you were doing a little grandstanding you know? And I was curious if this was a thing that they encouraged you to do?

BH: Well basically I'm a very mild-mannered trombone player. And I sort of have a laid back — and that sort of thing is not my real personality. And that's why I really don't enjoy doing that sort of thing, but I do know that the audience likes to see it. So I have just sort of forced myself to keep doing it throughout my career. And so I guess you have to do the bad things along with the good you know sometimes. And I don't really enjoy doing that sort of thing, it's just sort of exhibitionism, jumping around and doing all those acrobatic things. It's not my personality because I'm very quiet basically.

MR: What was it — being in the Welk organization, was it a pretty tight ship that they ran?

BH: Mr. Welk was a perfectionist music-wise, and he was very conscious of a person's appearance on television, as well as their musical ability. And he always wanted to keep a very clean cut looking group on television and at that time he didn't allow any beards or strange looking — well what was considered later the hippie style. He was very conscious of all that. And also he loved jazz music, but he had a tendency, when he got a few jazz people around, to try to sway their style a little bit to fit his thing. Well I think

his favorite instrument to feature was the clarinet. But of course he liked my trombone playing too. Now the clarinet, there was a lot of people that followed Pete Fountain in there. We had Peanuts Hucko and they had Henry Cuesta. Well all these other people, Lawrence would try to change their style a little bit. And they would get kind of perturbed at him. But some way or other, whatever I played he couldn't find anything to change. So he never bothered me. I just could play anything and it seemed to please him. But he was a musical perfectionist. He had a real good ear for music. And technically he did not know much about music. He didn't know how to write.

MR: He didn't do the arrangements.

BH: He didn't do any arranging, as a matter of fact his beginning in music was a correspondence course on accordion. And he started out as a chicken farmer back in North Dakota, and he was a failure at that. And so he decided to take a correspondence course in accordion. And he started out in the business that way as a single. And finally he worked his way into operating a full size orchestra. And he was a smart businessman. That was his other big asset, besides having a good ear. But he relied on George Kates, he was the musical director of the television show. He relied on him to make any changes musically, if something didn't suit him. If Lawrence didn't like the way something sounded, he would ask George to change it. He was a nice man to work for. I had no problem with him.

MR: He had a tap dancer on the show, and this woman — whose name I forget already—

BH: Joanne Castle.

MR: Said on the show that he was a black tap dancer, and she said that this was the first instance of a network show being integrated at all.

BH: Well there were not, still to this day there haven't been many musical shows that were dedicated to music completely in an hour's time. And I'd never thought about that, but that's probably true come to think about it. Arthur Duncan was who you are referring to. He was the black tap dancer. And up until — I think there was another, let's say a couple of years before — the other band later — Guy Lombardo, Guy Lombardo tried to do the same thing that Lawrence did, but he didn't go over for some reason. And they're very similar styles in music too. But I don't think there was any integration on that show, about 1954 you know. And I think that's probably true, that was the first show.

MR: And then I think Ralph Humphreys — were you on the band — Ralph Humphreys, the drummer?

BH: Paul Humphreys.

MR: Paul Humphreys.

BH: Yeah, Paul Humphreys was a black drummer and that was the second integration that happened.

MR: Gee it was a big group, too.

BH: Very large.

MR: In addition to the standard big band you had strings and a couple of other keyboard players.

BH: We had an organist, Barbara Olsten, and well then we had two piano players. One was Larry Hooper and he was a bass singer that went back to the beginning of the television show. Then we got Bob Smale to play piano also, and Bob Ralston was the organist. So he had three keyboards and two guitars and of course Myron Floren was the accordion; well it was a very large band. It was a total of about 54 people on an airplane when we would travel.

MR: And this was basically an every-day, like a full time job for you, right?

BH: Well now that I have been introduced to the Lawrence Welk stage show, I'm now working in the band at the theatre, I've discovered that it's much, much harder to do a stage production than it is television. A television show — I did it for twenty-two years — and there was a different program every week. We would rehearse two days. One day was sound rehearsal and the other day was sound and video. Well it involved about nineteen hours totally for each weekly show. Well I'm doing this theatre thing now, and I'm playing five hours a day, six days a week. And it's just like a Broadway show, like New York. I had never done anything like that before. Now I know how hard it is to adjust your mind to playing the same show, night after night. And it doesn't change. The only time it changes is if we bring a different Welk singer in, they do it for a couple of weeks at a time. They change the singers, but they don't change the Lennon Sisters, they don't change Joanne Castle or we have the Cathcart brothers and the Lennon Daughters.

MR: The Lennon Daughters. Gee, it must be like — to keep your concentration is probably —

BH: But I'm playing in the orchestra besides doing my own thing for a couple of numbers in the show, I'm playing all the music and it's the same show every night. And it's going to be this way for eight or nine months. And it takes a lot of changing in my mind to try to adjust to all of this. Because we only worked two days out of the week when we were on television. And this allowed me to go out and play jazz music, other engagements. And that added the variety in my career that was needed. I don't know whether I can last on this.

MR: Are you living there now? In Branson?

BH: I'm living in Branson. It's only temporary, but I don't know yet whether I'm going to continue on or not. But it's going to be a matter of whether I can get used to this stage type production. Well I've always heard about these shows that are running ten years at a time. I've always thought, how do the musicians do that — play the same music all the time?

MR: Do you get any residuals or anything from all those years on TV?

BH: Yes. All of the members that were involved in the original television production receive residuals from the Welk Corporation.

MR: The musician's union was fairly strong in their influence?

BH: The residual idea I think started in the early 60s, something like that. Anything on television that was before oh about 1961 or 2 I guess, there's no residuals involved. So that's why you see a lot of those old shows that date way back. Because they don't have to deal with the residuals. But we were fortunate and started at a time where this agreement had already been struck with the union, and so we do get the re-run money from that.

MR: So how did they make the bubbles?

BH: Well there was a bubble machine. As a matter of fact I always like to tell a joke with the audiences, that I don't really play on the show, I just operate the bubble machine. But it was a circular wheel with holes, maybe five or six holes in this wheel. And the wheel would rotate down into a can with soapy water, and this wheel would just turn around and there was a fan that blowed through the holes and up into the air came the bubbles, behind the bandstand. And that was the first thing you would see on television, when the show started.

MR: Did they take the bubble machine on the road?

BH: We did have a traveling bubble machine, yes. And we all would hate that because it would get on our clothes and then on the horns.

MR: Who would ever think of those little things you know?

BH: Well I'll tell you it seems like everything Mr. Welk did turned to gold. He was such a smart man and he knew exactly what the average public wanted to hear.

MR: Yes, I know. People would make jokes about him you know, but as they say, he was laughing all the way to the bank I guess.

BH: No, I've had a very rewarding career. All the people that I used to hear on records, the individual jazz players, I've been able to play with most of them in my own time, and it's just been a wonderful experience. And I'm still, up to this year, I've been freelancing in the jazz concerts and jazz parties, and it's still continuing to be a lot of fun as well as financially rewarding too.

MR: Well I hope it continues for you.

BH: Well I hope so too. Well I had sort of semi-retired myself a few years ago. But I'm discovering that I'm not quite as happy just sitting around the house listening to records as I have been doing actual performing. So I think I may just keep up as long as I can physically hold the horn I'll probably play.

MR: Good. But maybe you shouldn't do the thing on your back.

BH: No, I tried to retire that completely, until they called me to the theatre there. And now I've already, this year, laid on my back 150 times, and I have that many more to go. But I'm going to draw the line after this year.

MR: It was such a serendipitous thing that you did that one night.

BH: Just as a joke one night, and it's continued throughout my career. And now when somebody comes up to me and says, "You're one of my favorite trombone player and do you still do that number where you lay on the floor" that's always the first thing they can think of.

MR: Well this has been fascinating, and thanks so much for sharing your time with us.

BH: Well it's been a pleasure talking with you, Monk. I hope this is beneficial to whoever likes to observe it. I always like to talk about my career, because I feel really fortunate that things just sort of fell into place. I never really had to work at progressing in my career. I seemed to be at the right place at the right time, which is very fortunate. But you know I think when it comes to jazz, you have to have some natural talent to really go far with it. It's something that schooling doesn't do a complete job with. You have to have that inside of you, you're like sort of born with it.

MR: I agree. All right well on behalf of Hamilton College, thank you very much, and good luck in Branson and tonight, with your music.

BH: Thank you, Monk.